

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 3



CHAPTER 3



WORD FROM THE *PILGRIM*

The weeks passed and months. No word from Tom Perry. Time came to start to school.

Lizza said, "I'm glad I'm not going. They say Master Watson is grouchy. Are you scared about going to school, Nat?"

Nat shook his head. "No, I'm not scared . . . very much."

But when he and Hab entered the schoolhouse, and Master Watson bristled his eyebrows at them, Nat's knees began to shake.

Master Watson glared at Nat. "What's he doing here?"

"He's just little for his age, Master Watson," Hab said.

"He's gone to school two years in Danvers."

Master Watson snorted. "A dame school! Women!"

He glared at Nat again. "Sit over there with the young ones. And keep still!"

"Yes, sir." Nat climbed on a bench and sat.

Hour after hour, all morning, he sat and listened. When they came back in the afternoon, he sat and listened again. If only he could answer a question the very first day! Then Master Watson wouldn't glare at him because he was little.

Three times that day Nat knew an answer. But before he could get his hand up, someone else answered the question.

It was almost time for school to let out. Through the window, Nat heard a fife shrilling and the thud of a drum. Another privateer was making ready for sea. They were drumming up a crew!

Master Watson's voice broke in on Nat's thoughts. "What happened on April 19, 1775?"

At last! He could answer that question! Nat stood up on the bench and waved his hand. "I know! I know!"

Master Watson's eyebrows bristled. "Well? Speak up!"

Nat took a deep breath. "On April 19, 1775, my father's sloop, *Polly*, went aground on Anguilla Reef. And —"

Nat stopped with a gasp. Master Watson had grabbed his shoulders and was shaking him.

Jerkily, through the shaking, Nat heard Hab's voice. "It's true, Master Watson! Nat wasn't trying to be smart!"

Nat didn't remember anything else until Master Watson said, "School is dismissed!" And he was outside, walking up the street with Hab.

"Hab, what was the matter? What I said was true. It was the right answer!"

Hab tried to explain. The Battle of Lexington was

very important. When anyone asked about April 19, 1775, the Battle of Lexington would be the right answer — no matter what else happened on that day.

Nat said, “Huh! I like arithmetic better. Two plus two is four. Always. Nobody’s going to shake you when you say that.”

Hab chuckled. “That’s it, Nat. You stick to arithmetic. He’ll never shake you for that.”

But Master Watson did not give arithmetic problems to boys Nat’s size. Not real ones. Every problem Nat got he could work in his head.

Maybe next year, he thought, I’ll get bigger problems. Big enough to work on my slate. Maybe next year will be more fun at school.

But next year wasn't more fun. Nat had to go to school alone. Hab was twelve, now, and he stopped school to help Father make barrels. Their luck had not changed.

One day Nat sighed as he watched Master Watson put a nice, long problem on a big boy's slate. He held up his hand. "Please, sir, could I have one of those big problems, too?"

Master Watson glared. "No! You're too little! I haven't time to bother with you!"

That night after supper Father said, "What's the matter, son?"

"Master Watson won't give me big problems to work on my slate, just little ones I can do in my head."

Father chuckled. "First time I ever heard a boy complain about that! We'll see what we can do!" He brought paper and ink to the table, and sharpened a quill. He wrote a note, and dusted it with sand to dry the ink.

"Here you are. How does this sound?" He read:

Master Watson

My son, Nat, likes arithmetic. Will you please give him bigger problems to work?

Your obedient servant

HABAKKUK BOWDITCH

The next day Master Watson read the note and scowled. He grabbed Nat's slate and pencil. The pencil went *squeak, squeak*, filling half the slate with a problem.

"There! That will keep you busy for a while!"

Nat hurried to his seat and worked the problem. When he had the answer, he checked it over to be sure it was right. He grinned. The answer came out the same both times. That's what he liked about arithmetic. He carried his slate to Master Watson's desk. "Please sir, may I have another problem?"

Master Watson snorted. "Too hard for you, eh? No, you may not have another problem! Work on that one until you get the answer!"

"But I've got the answer!"

"Eh?" Master Watson grabbed the slate and checked the problem. "Who helped you?"

"No one!"

Master Watson slapped his hand down on his desk. "Don't lie to me! Who helped you?"

Nat forgot about being afraid of Master Watson. He clenched his fists and yelled, "I don't tell lies!"

Master Watson grabbed up his ruler. For a long time

he stared at Nat. Then he spoke through his teeth. "You have until tomorrow to tell me the truth. Tomorrow, if you don't tell me who helped you, I'll give you a whaling you'll never forget!"

That night at supper Granny said, "Eat your supper, Nat."

But Nat couldn't seem to swallow. He chewed and chewed each bite until it somehow went away.

After supper, Hab said, "What's the matter, Nat?"

Nat told him about the problem. "I didn't think he'd ever scold me about arithmetic, but he did."

Hab squared his shoulders and stuck out his lower lip. "Don't worry, Nat. I'll take care of that. In the morning!"

The next morning he marched to school with Nat. "Master Watson," he said, "Nat can't help it if he likes arithmetic."

Master Watson snapped, "He never worked that problem that fast without help! And no one can make me believe he did!"

"Why don't you give him another one," Hab asked, "and stand right over him while he works it?"

"I'll do that very thing." Master Watson snatched the slate. This time the problem covered almost all of one side. "All right, work that! Right here at my desk, where I can keep an eye on you!"

Nat shivered. The numbers on the slate jiggled but he gulped and began to work. He could feel Master Watson's eyes glaring down at him. After a little, though, he forgot all about Master Watson. His own problem! A big one. And it would come out right.

Arithmetic always did. Swiftly he worked, finished it, checked it, and looked up.

"There!"

Master Watson stared with his mouth open. "I — I — it's hard to believe — even when you see it happen." He held out his hand. "Nat, I'm sorry about yesterday. Will you shake hands on it?"

"Yes, sir. And please may I have another problem?"

"What!"

Hab said, "Look, Nat, Master Watson can't spend all day writing problems for you!"

"It's all right. I'll give him another problem." Master Watson shook his head again. "I never saw anything like it. Nat, if you knew half as much Latin as you know arithmetic, you could enter Harvard tomorrow!"

That night at supper Nat asked, "What's Harvard?"

Mother and Father chuckled. Granny said, "Oldest college in the country. Whatever made you think of Harvard?"

Hab told them what Master Watson had said.

Mother beamed and hugged Nat. "That's wonderful, Nat. And you shall go to college. Some day you'll be a Harvard man."

Granny said, "He might as well; never going to be sizable enough to handle a ship. Come a gale at sea, you'd have to ballast his feet. Takes a heap of money, though, to go to Harvard."

"When the war's over, times will get better," Mother said.

Lizza rolled her eyes at Nat. He knew she was thinking about his expectation. When Tom Perry came back, Nat would have plenty of money for Harvard.

After supper he and Lizza walked down Turner's Lane and out on the wharf.

Lizza said, "I wish Tom Perry would come."

"He will, some day."

"But, Nat, how will you know where to find him?"

"He'll find me," Nat said. "He knows my name."

The spring Nat was eight, Granny said, "You know where Dr. Stearns' apothecary shop is, Nat?"

Mother said, "Nonsense, dear. I'm all right. We can't afford — "

"We can't afford to lose you." Granny wrote something on a piece of paper and said, "Take this to Dr. Stearns, Nat."

Nat felt a cold lump in his stomach. He ran all the way to Dr. Stearns' shop, and gave him the paper. "It's medicine! For Mother! Please hurry!"

"No cause to worry, Nat. It's just a tonic." Dr. Stearns gave Nat the *Salem Gazette*. "Read this, why don't you, while you wait."

Nat looked at the paper. The first thing that caught his eye was the word Pilgrim. He read the advertisement:

At BEVERLY

That copper-bottom, fast-sailing, frigate-built ship,
MARS... captured by the PILGRIM, Joseph Robinson,
Commander,

Will be sold Wednesday, 11, instant, at 10 o'clock.

Nat carried the paper to Dr. Stearns. "When's 'eleven instant'?"

"Eleventh of this month." He glanced at the paper. "Reading about the auction of the *Mars*, eh? Did you ever see the auction of a prize ship?"

"No, sir."

"It's a sale. There's a man they call the 'auctioneer.' He puts everything up for sale. Whoever offers the most money gets whatever the auctioneer is selling right then. That's going to be quite a sale. Captain Robinson will make a pretty penny from the *Mars*."

Nat said, "I have a friend on the *Pilgrim*. Tom Perry."

"That so? Well, your friend Tom Perry will make a pretty penny, too. I'll be over at Beverly for the auction. I'll ask about him." He gave Nat a packet. "There's the medicine, Nat."

The cold lump came back in Nat's stomach. He ran all the way home. He watched anxiously while Mother mixed a dose and took it. "Do you feel better now?"

"Much better, dear." Mother smiled. "It's nasty enough to make anyone well!"

Nat sighed with relief and ran to tell Lizza about the auction of the *Mars*. "Next week, on the twelfth, we'll go to Dr. Stearns' shop. He'll have news about Tom Perry!"

On the afternoon of the twelfth, Lizza and Nat got the paper from its hiding place and hurried up the street.

"Nat, what will you get first with all your money?"

"A new ship for Father — bigger than the *Polly*. And then presents for everybody else."

"What will you get for you?"

"I'm going to save my money to go to Harvard."

"Oh, Nat!" Lizza smiled and squeezed his hand.

Nat smiled, too. "Did I tell you what Tom Perry called me? He called me 'Mate.' "

When they got to the apothecary shop, Dr. Stearns was busy talking to the Reverend Dr. Prince and Dr. Holyoke. A big stack of books was on the counter, and the men were looking at them.

Dr. Holyoke said, "You can't tear pages out of these books to wrap your drugs in!"

The apothecary shrugged. "Paper's scarce!"

"But these books are priceless!"

Dr. Stearns rubbed his chin and smiled. "I tell you what. If you want these books, I'll sell them to you for just what I paid for them at the auction: one hundred and fifty-eight pounds and ten shillings."

"In hard money?" Dr. Prince asked.

"No, in continental currency."

Dr. Holyoke said, "In hard money, not quite forty pounds. Will you give us a week to raise the money?"

The apothecary pursed his lips. "Well, yes — but I may use a few pages here and there to wrap a few drugs . . ."

Dr. Holyoke roared, "Don't you dare touch a page!"

Dr. Stearns laughed and promised. When the men had gone, he said, "Well, hello there, Nat — and Lizza! I didn't see you!"

"Did you find out about my friend Tom Perry?"

"Yes, Nat." He came from behind his counter, upended a box, and sat down. "A friend of yours, was he?"

"Yes, sir. A good friend. He called me 'Mate.' "

"Then you can be mighty proud of him, Nat. He died a hero. It happened almost a year ago. The *Pilgrim's* men were boarding an English ship. It was close, hand-

to-hand fighting. A Britisher leveled a gun at the *Pilgrim's* first mate. Tom Perry leaped for the man. He caught the gun blast full in his chest. They buried him at sea — a hero."

Nat's throat ached. His tongue felt dry. He licked his lips. "Thank you for finding out for me."

Slowly Nat and Lizza went back to Turner's Lane. They walked out on the wharf and stared across the endless, empty water.

Lizza whispered, "It's wonderful to have a friend that was a hero, Nat. To have him call you 'Mate' and everything."

Nat swallowed hard.

After a little, Lizza said, "Nat, did you ever hear about what fishermen's people do when a fisherman dies and is buried at sea? The people at home scatter flowers on the water to remember him by."

Nat pulled the slip of paper from his pocket. Slowly he tore it in tiny pieces and let them fall in the water.

Lizza whispered, "If you squinch your eyes, it looks just exactly like little flowers . . . almost . . ." She squeezed his hand. "Times will get better, Nat — when the war's over."

Nat shivered. No expectation now. No new ship for Father, no presents. No money to go to Harvard. Nothing.

Lizza whispered, "Good-by, Tom Perry."

Nat said, "Good-by." He was saying good-by to a lot of things.